A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies

Bartolomé de las Casas · 1552

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A Spanish Dominican friar who had been an early colonist, las Casas came to condemn the brutal treatment of Native peoples under the encomienda system. Writing to the Spanish Crown, he catalogued atrocities to argue for reform. His account fueled the "Black Legend" of Spanish cruelty and remains a powerful — if one-sided — window into the human cost of conquest and the Columbian Exchange.

Connect: How does las Casas's purpose — persuading the Crown to reform — shape what he chose to describe and how he described it?

Key Passages

On the peoples of the Indies

Now this infinite multitude of men are by the Creation of God innocently simple, altogether void of and averse to all manner of craft, subtlety and malice, and most obedient and loyal subjects to their native sovereigns;

On the conduct of the conquerors

The Spaniards first assaulted the innocent sheep, so qualified by the Almighty, as is mentioned above, like most cruel tigers, wolves and lions hunger-starved, … that of three millions of persons, which lived in Hispaniola itself, there is at present but the inconsiderable remnant of scarce three hundred.

On the division of the people

they divided among themselves the young men, women, and children reserved promiscuously [indiscriminately] for that purpose, one obtained thirty, another forty, to this man one hundred were disposed, … they sent the males to the mines to dig and bring away the gold, which is an intolerable labor; … the men died in mines, hunger starved and oppressed with labor, and the women perished in the fields, harassed and broken with the like evils and calamities: Thus an infinite number of inhabitants that formerly peopled this island were exterminated and dwindled away to nothing by such consumptions [wasting away].

On the motive of the Spaniards

The Spaniards first set sail to America, not for the honor of God, or as persons moved and merited thereunto by fervent zeal to the true faith, … but in truth, only stimulated and goaded on by insatiable avarice and ambition, that they might for ever domineer, command, and tyrannize over the West-Indians,

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Spanish conquest of the Caribbean and Mexico and the encomienda system forced Native peoples into labor; war, abuse, and disease caused their populations to collapse.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The Spanish Crown (Prince Philip, later Philip II) and royal officials who could reform colonial policy; the printed book soon reached readers across Europe.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	A Dominican friar and former encomienda holder turned reformer; writing to win reform, he stresses Spanish cruelty, and Native voices appear only through his account.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the encomienda system on Native populations.
2. How might las Casas's role as a friar have shaped both his message and his intended audience?
3. Why should historians read this source critically even though it defends Native peoples?

A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies

Bartolomé de las Casas · 1542

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> A Spanish friar's searing eyewitness indictment of the cruelty of the conquistadors toward Native peoples — a founding document of the movement to protect indigenous rights and a source of the "Black Legend" of Spanish colonization.

On the peoples of the Indies

Now this infinite multitude of men are by the Creation of God innocently simple, altogether void of and averse to all manner of craft, subtlety and malice, and most obedient and loyal subjects to their native sovereigns; and behave themselves very patiently, submissively and quietly towards the Spaniards, to whom they are subservient and subject; so that finally they live without the least thirst after revenge, laying aside all litigiousness [quarreling], commotion and hatred.

[. . .]

On the conduct of the conquerors

The Spaniards first assaulted the innocent sheep, so qualified by the Almighty, as is mentioned above, like most cruel tigers, wolves and lions hunger-starved, studying nothing, for the space of forty years, after their first landing, but the massacre of these wretches, whom they have so inhumanely and barbarously butchered and harassed with several kinds of torments, never before known, or heard (of which you shall have some account in the following discourse) that of three millions of persons, which lived in Hispaniola itself, there is at present but the inconsiderable remnant of scarce three hundred.

[. . .]

On the scale of loss

Nay we dare boldly affirm, that during the forty years space, wherein they exercised their sanguinary [bloody] and detestable tyranny in these regions, above twelve millions (computing men, women, and children) have undeservedly perished; nor do I conceive that I should deviate from the truth by saying that above fifty millions in all paid their last debt to nature. . . . Now the ultimate end and scope that incited the Spaniards to endeavor the extirpation [rooting out] and desolation of this people, was gold only; that thereby growing opulent [rich] in a short time, they might arrive at once at such degrees and dignities, as were no ways consistent with their persons.

[. . .]

Hispaniola

From which time they began to consider by what ways and means they might expel the Spaniards out of their country, and immediately took up arms. But, good God, what arms, do you imagine? Namely such, both offensive and defensive, as resemble reeds wherewith boys sport with one another, more than manly arms and weapons. Which the Spaniards no sooner perceived, but they, mounted on generous steeds, well armed with lances and swords, begin to exercise their bloody butcheries and stratagems, and overrunning their cities and towns, spared no age, or sex, nay not so much as women with child, but ripping up their bellies, tore them alive in pieces. They laid wagers among themselves, who should with a sword at one blow cut, or divide a man in two; or which of them should decollate [cut off the head of] or behead a man, with the greatest dexterity; nay farther, which should sheath his sword in the bowels of a man with the quickest dispatch and expedition. . . . I once saw four or five of their most powerful lords laid on these gridirons [grills], and thereon roasted, and not far off, two or three more over-spread with the same commodity, man's flesh; but the shrill clamors which were heard there being offensive to the captain, by hindering his repose, he commanded them to be strangled with a halter [rope].

[. . .]

Dividing the people among the conquerors

The warlike engagements being over, and the inhabitants all swept away, they divided among themselves the young men, women, and children reserved promiscuously [indiscriminately] for that purpose, one obtained thirty, another forty, to this man one hundred were disposed, to the other two hundred, and the more one was in favor with the domineering tyrant (which they styled governor) the more he became master of, upon this pretence, and with this proviso [condition], that he should see them instructed in the Catholic religion, when as they themselves to whom they were committed to be taught, and the care of their souls instructed them were, for the major part idiots, cruel, avaricious, infected and stained with all sorts of vices. And this was the great care they had of them, they sent the males to the mines to dig and bring away the gold, which is an intolerable labor; but the women they made use of to manure [cultivate] and till the ground, which is a toil most irksome even to men of the strongest and most robust constitutions, allowing them no other food but herbage [plants], and such kind of unsubstantial nutriment, so that the nursing women's milk was exsiccated [dried out] and so dried up, that the young infants lately brought forth, all perished, and females being separated from and debarred cohabitation with men, there was no prolification [bearing of children] or raising up issue among them. The men died in mines, hunger starved and oppressed with labor, and the women perished in the fields, harassed and broken with the like evils and calamities: Thus an infinite number of inhabitants that formerly peopled this island were exterminated and dwindled away to nothing by such consumptions [wasting away].

[. . .]

Epilogue

The Spaniards first set sail to America, not for the honor of God, or as persons moved and merited thereunto by fervent zeal to the true faith, nor to promote the salvation of their neighbors, nor to serve the king, as they falsely boast and pretend to do, but in truth, only stimulated and goaded on by insatiable avarice and ambition, that they might for ever domineer, command, and tyrannize over the West-Indians, whose kingdoms they hoped to divide and distribute among themselves.

Words to know

subservient — placed under another's control and forced to obey

inconsiderable remnant — a tiny leftover group

paid their last debt to nature — died

stratagems — tricks and schemes used in warfare

pretence — a false excuse put forward to justify an action

insatiable avarice — greed that can never be satisfied